



PATH 16

Freelance, then productize

Charge the rate now. Build the product from the notes. Stop reinventing the job.

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Who this is for

You already do AI work for money and you are tired of quoting from scratch.

Time to first

You may already be here

Tools

First sale

A second similar job at a cleaner scope.

Cash window

Your current rate, then a package

Leave this alone

Whatever you already invoice with, plus a growing checklist. Random gigs forever. No notes.

What this actually is

You already do AI work for money. Someone asks what you charge. You shrug an hourly number, or you write a custom proposal that eats an evening, or you say yes to a job that does not look like the last one because variety feels like growth. This path is the decision to stop reinventing the job.

Take the last job you did well. Write the steps as a checklist the night you deliver. After three similar jobs, the package writes itself. That package is path 7 — a named service with a date and a price. The checklist is path 1 — a playbook a stranger can run without you.

Charge the rate now. Build the product from the notes. You do not pause income to ‘work on the business.’ You take similar work on purpose, you write it down, and you send a package name the next time someone asks what you charge.

Variety feels like growth. It is usually stalling. AI made it faster. That is what they are buying. Do not undercharge because the draft arrived in twelve minutes. Speed is the offer, not a reason to discount.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if invoices already exist. You have done AI-assisted work for other people — posts, listings, research briefs, internal SOPs — and you can open a folder of paid jobs. You are tired of quoting from scratch. You may already be here.

It fits if you can tell the truth about which jobs were similar. Same kind of input, same kind of output, roughly the same number of days. A realtor listing pack and a dentist listing pack can be similar. A realtor listing pack and a custom chatbot are not.

Skip this if

Skip it if you have never been paid. You cannot productize a fantasy. Skip it if you refuse to write notes. The notes are the whole conversion. Skip it if you want to stop service this month and ‘only sell digital products.’ The honest road is three similar jobs, a named package, then a cheaper file of the job without you in the middle.

If you already run a productized package, this path is still yours: raise when the waitlist appears, and spin the checklist into a file. You are on step 9.

The offer, named in one sentence

When they ask your rate, **name the package, not an hourly shrug.**

The sentence: **[Named result] in [N days] for [price]. You get [files]. One revision. You provide [inputs].** ‘I can help with AI’ is not an offer.

Offers that come from real invoices

12 posts and one landing draft in 7 days for \$600. You get files, not a login to my brain.

8 listing descriptions plus a Google Business week in 5 days for \$450.

Inbox to 15 follow-up emails in 10 days for \$750, built in your voice.

You do not invent this on a branding retreat. You circle the similar invoices, write the shared steps, and name what you already delivered. The **service package** is you in the middle. The **product version** is the job without you, priced lower. Do not refuse paid work while you ‘wait to productize.’ Charge now. Notes tonight.

What done looks like

Done for the first 72 hours: last three invoices open, similar ones circled, shared steps written, package named, and that name sitting in a note you will paste the next time someone asks what you charge.

Done for the first sale of this path: **a second similar job at a cleaner scope.** Not a bigger job. A cleaner one. Same shape as the last, written scope, deposit, one revision, a date. If you still

said ‘sure, I can also do the chatbot and the brand voice and the ads,’ you smiled. You did not productize.

A job is done when the night-of-delivery notes exist in the same doc you always use: steps, prompts you reused, what they failed to provide, how long it actually took, what you will refuse next time.

A package is done when you can send it without opening a blank proposal. Name, deliverable, timeline, price, inputs, revision rule. One page. The product version is later: the checklist a stranger can run without you. This path’s finish line is the named package and the habit of notes.

Pricing and the cash window

The cash window is **your current rate, then a package**. You do not cut your rate to ‘make it productized.’ You stop pretending every job is unique.

If you already charge \$75/hour, and a job eats 8 hours including the smiling and the revisions, the package is not \$200 because AI drafted fast. The package is **\$600–\$900** with a date, or whatever math matches the last invoices plus a little for the cleaner scope. Speed is what they buy. You keep the surplus.

If you have been undercharging, do not leap to \$5,000 because a thread told you to. Average the last three similar invoices. Round up to a number you can say without coughing. That is v1. Raise when a waitlist appears — meaning someone has to wait a week or you are turning people away.

First packages in this suite’s service path often live at **\$300–\$1,500**. A 3-day listing pack can be \$400. A 10-day follow-up system can be \$900. A 14-day content-plus-page can be \$1,200. Write what is in and what is out so the number has a spine. Deposit before you open the chat. **50% to start**.

When the checklist is boring because you have run it three times, price the file at **\$19–\$47**. Cheaper than hiring you. That is the point. It does not replace the \$600 until you want it to.

The first 72 hours

You are not building a new brand. You are opening invoices.

Hours 1–3: circle

Open the last three invoices, or the last five if three is too thin. Circle the similar ones. Similar = same kind of input, same kind of output, same-ish days. If none are similar, circle the one you would be willing to do again, and treat the next yes as the second data point. Write the names of the jobs on a sticky: ‘listing packs,’ not ‘misc AI help.’

Hours 4–8: shared steps

From the circled jobs, write the shared steps in a single doc. Intake, inputs you needed, the AI draft pass, the edit pass, the delivery folder, the walkthrough, the revision window. Put the prompts you reused under the step where you used them. This doc is the company.

Day 2–3: name, one-pager, paste

Name the package like a result: ‘7-day listing pack.’ Write what’s in, what’s not, timeline, price (from the invoices, rounded up), what they must provide, one revision. Put the name in a note on your phone. The next time someone asks ‘what do you charge?’ you send the package, not an hourly shrug. If nobody is asking this week, send the one-pager to two past clients who already liked the work.

Last invoices open, similar ones circled

Shared steps in one doc

Package named, one page

Paste ready for the next ‘what do you charge?’

The path, step by step

Step 1. Open the last three invoices and circle the similar ones. If you cannot find similarity, you have been collecting gigs. The next yes should look like the best of those jobs, not a new species.

- Step 2. Write the steps the night you deliver.** Same day, while the mess is still in your head. Tomorrow you will only remember the win. The product lives in the missing inputs, the prompt that worked, the extra round they talked you into.
- Step 3. Notes in the same doc after every job.** One running file. Dated entries. Do not start a new Notion palace per client.
- Step 4. Prompts you reused go in a stack.** If you typed it twice, it belongs in a block you can paste. That stack becomes part of the package and, later, part of a file.
- Step 5. Name the package.** Result, days, price. Stop the hourly shrug. Practice saying it out loud once so you do not fold on a call.
- Step 6. Write what's in, what's out, the date, the deposit.** One revision is enough. Unlimited revisions is how packages die. They must provide voice, examples, and access on day one or the clock does not start.
- Step 7. Send that name the next time someone asks what you charge.** Even if the one-pager is ugly. A named package is cleaner than a charming email.
- Step 8. Stop saying yes to work that does not teach the product.** A flattering weird gig will pay once and steal the notes week. Refer it or decline.
- Step 9. After three similar jobs, the package writes itself.** You are not guessing scope. You have dates and hours. Tighten the one-pager. That package is path 7. The checklist is path 1.
- Step 10. Raise the package price when the waitlist appears.** Waitlist means delay or a no because you are full. Add 15–30%, keep the scope. Do not add more deliverables to justify the raise.
- Step 11. Make the product version: the job without you in the middle.** Price it lower. Let it sell while you sleep. Do this after the checklist is boring, not instead of the next paid job.
- Step 12. Do not undercharge because AI made it fast.** They bought speed and judgment. If a job that used to take a day now takes three hours, you did not become cheaper. You became a better package. Keep the price. Shrink the timeline if you want, on purpose, as part of the offer.

A worked example: Drew names the package

Drew has been ‘doing AI stuff’ for six months. Invoices: \$400 to rewrite a dentist’s Google posts, \$650 to draft listing copy for a realtor friend, \$300 to ‘just help with ChatGPT’ for a cousin’s bakery, \$800 for another realtor’s listings plus a landing page. Drew quotes from scratch every time.

Tuesday night, Drew circles the two realtor jobs and, after a pause, the dentist posts. Same shape: messy facts in, a week of public-facing copy out. The bakery cousin is not circled. Sticky note: ‘do not take cousin work.’

Shared steps go in one doc that night: intake, folder of inputs, draft pass, human edit, delivery in a Google doc they own, 15-minute walkthrough, one revision window of 5 days. Reused prompts get pasted under the draft step.

Wednesday, Drew names it: **8 listings and one page draft in 7 days for \$750**. Out: ads, chatbots, unlimited rounds. Deposit 50%. The one-pager is a Google doc. Ugly. Fine.

Thursday, an acquaintance asks what Drew would charge ‘to help with AI.’ Drew pastes the package name instead of ‘I usually do \$75 an hour.’ The acquaintance is not a realtor. Drew says this package is for listings and a page. Two hours saved.

The next realtor who asks, week 2, gets the same paste. They say yes. Deposit lands before the chat. Drew delivers in 6 days, writes the notes that night (they always forget parking details; add that to intake). That is the first sale of this path: **a second similar job at a cleaner scope**.

After the third listing-pack job, Drew raises to \$900 when a fourth has to wait a week. The checklist is boring enough to become a \$27 playbook. The file sells twice in a month while Drew is inside a paid week. The hourly shrug is gone. The cousin still wants ‘a little help.’ Drew sends the playbook link.

Copy you can paste

When they ask what you charge

I do not bill a pile of hours for this anymore. It is a named package: **[result] in [N] days for [price]**. You get [files], one revision, and a short walkthrough. You provide [inputs] on day one. Deposit holds the week. Here is the one-pager.

One-pager headline

[Result] in [N] days. You get files, not a login to my brain.

Scope block

In: [deliverables]. Out: [the usual extras — extra rounds, extra channels, strategy decks, sitting in their Slack]. Timeline: [start when inputs arrive, end on date]. Price: [amount]. Deposit: 50% before I open the work. Revisions: one round within 5 days of delivery.

Notes template, the night you deliver

Date. Client type. What they provided / what they skipped. Steps I actually ran. Prompts I reused. Hours start to finish. What I will refuse next time. One line I could sell as a file.

Decline that teaches the product

This sounds like a custom build, and I am not taking those. If you want [the named package], I have a seat in [week]. If you want to run it without me, the [playbook / stack] is [price] and it is the same steps.

Raise, when they wait

The package is [new price] starting [date]. Same scope. I am booking [N] weeks out. Deposit still holds the slot.

Week-by-week

This week. Circle similar invoices. Write the shared steps. Name the package. Put the paste on your phone. Do not rebuild your website.

Next job. Send the package name. Take a deposit. Run the job. Notes in the same doc the night you deliver. Prompts you reused go in the stack.

After two similar jobs. Tighten what's in and what's out. If you got burned by extra rounds, the one-revision line gets bolder, not politer.

After three similar jobs. The package is real. Stop custom proposals for this shape of work. Start saying no to work that does not teach it. Sketch the product version from the checklist — but do not disappear from paid weeks to design a cover.

When a waitlist appears. Raise 15–30%. Keep the scope. Do not celebrate by adding deliverables.

When the checklist is boring. Ship the cheaper file. Mention it after delivery and to people who cannot afford the package. Keep taking packages until you choose not to.

Every week you deliver anything. Notes that night. If you skip the notes, you skipped the path. The invoice is the job. The notes are the company.

Quality bar

They never see the raw model output. That is the floor. AI drafts. You edit. Quality is your name, not the model's.

Floor for a package job

Written scope before work. Deposit before chat.

Inputs listed. Clock starts when they arrive.

Human pass on every deliverable. Facts checked. Voice matches their examples, not 'an AI that heard of their industry.'

Delivery in a folder they own. A 15-minute walkthrough. One revision window with a date.

Notes the night you deliver, in the same doc.

Floor for the conversion

Similarity is real, not branded. You can say in one sentence what matches across the circled jobs.

The package name is a result plus a date plus a price. If it needs a paragraph of hedging, it is still a shrug.

You declined at least one job that would have felt like growth and would have taught nothing.

Cleaner scope means the second similar job has fewer side quests than the first. Fewer extra rounds. Fewer ‘while you’re in there.’ If the second job is bigger and fuzzier, you went the wrong direction.

What to measure

Similar jobs in a row. Two is the first-sale line. Three writes the package. Randomness is the enemy; count streaks.

Proposal time. Minutes from ‘what do you charge’ to a sent package. If this is still two hours, you do not have a package. You have a ritual.

Hours per package vs price. Know the number. Raise or tighten scope if the surplus disappears.

Revision count. More than one as a habit means your definition of done is soft or your intake is weak.

Notes completed the night of delivery. Binary. This is the leading indicator of a future file.

Nos to off-shape work. If this is zero, you are still collecting gigs.

Waitlist days. When people wait, raise. When they do not, do not panic-discount. Improve the ask list.

Product-version sales, later. Separate from package revenue. Do not kill a \$900 week because a \$27 file feels more ‘scalable’ on a slide.

Do not measure how many different industries you have touched. That is a stalling trophy.

Objections you will hear — including from yourself

‘Every client is unique.’ Their business is unique. The job is not. Eight listings and a page is eight listings and a page. Unique belongs in their facts, not in your process.

‘I will productize after I quit clients.’ You will have no notes, no proof, and no cash. Charge now. Notes tonight. File later.

‘AI made it fast, so I should charge less.’ They are buying the speed. Keep the price. Offer a shorter timeline if you want the speed visible.

‘A package will make me miss interesting work.’ It will. That is the trade. Interesting work that never repeats is a class you pay for with your calendar. Take one on purpose once a quarter if you must.

‘I need a new website first.’ You need a one-pager and a paste.

‘What if they want hourly?’ You can say no. If a trusted client insists, cap the hours and still write the steps. Do not live there.

‘I only have one invoice.’ Circle that one. Aim the next yes at the same shape. The first sale is the second similar job.

What feeds this path

The last jobs. Invoices, emails, folders, Slack threads. Mine them before you invent a niche.

The night-of-delivery doc. Every entry feeds the one-pager and, later, the file. Skip a night and the feed dries up.

People who already paid you. They are the easiest second similar job. ‘If you need this again, it has a name now.’

The questions inside the job. ‘Can you also...’ is how you learn what to put in ‘what’s out.’ Intake gets sharper. The package gets kinder to you.

Prompts you reused. They are a stack waiting to happen. Do not leave them in chat history.

What does not feed it. Job boards that want a new species every time. ‘Happy to help with anything AI.’ Those feeds train the shrug. When a week has no freelance work, the feed is still the doc. Clean it. Send two past clients the one-pager. Do not fill the week with a random gig so you feel busy.

Mistakes

Random gigs forever. No notes. You will be as good at quoting from scratch in December as you were in March, only more tired. The notes are the path.

Custom work that never repeats. It feels like a portfolio. It is a stall. If it does not teach the package, it is a no.

Undercharging because AI ‘made it fast.’ Speed is the product. Keep the rate. Tighten the days if you want. Put the days on the package. Be done when you are done.

Working before the deposit. The ‘quick call’ becomes the job. Deposit first.

Unlimited revisions. Then there is no definition of done, and the checklist cannot be written because the job never ends.

Building the file instead of taking the second similar job. The file will be theoretical. Take the job. Write it down. Then productize.

A menu of 12 services. If you have twelve, you have none. One package. Not a cafeteria.

Tools

Whatever you already invoice with. Stripe, HoneyBook, an invoice PDF, Venmo with a paper trail. Do not switch billing tools this week.

A growing checklist in one doc. Google Doc, Notion, a notes app. One. Dated. Ugly.

A one-page agreement. Scope, date, price, deposit, one revision, what they provide. You can reuse this 20 times.

A deposit link. Same as the invoice tool. 50% before the chat.

The prompt stack you actually reused, sitting under the step where it belongs.

You do not need a new CRM to productize. You do not need a scheduler until people are actually booking. You do not need a course platform to turn the checklist into a \$27 file — a PDF and a payment link will do when the time comes. The bottleneck is not software. It is writing the steps the night you deliver and sending a name instead of a shrug.

Checklist

This week

Last three invoices open. Similar ones circled.

Shared steps in one doc.

Package named: result, days, price.

What's in / what's out / deposit / one revision.

Paste saved for 'what do you charge?'

Every job

Deposit before the chat. Clock starts when inputs arrive.

They never see raw model output.

Deliver in a folder they own. Walkthrough. One revision window.

Notes in the same doc the night you deliver.

Reused prompts copied into the stack.

After three similar jobs

Stop custom proposals for this shape.

No to work that does not teach the product.

Raise when people wait.

Outline the cheaper file from the boring checklist. Ship it without quitting the paid package.

FAQ

I only have messy one-off jobs. Can I still start?

Yes. Circle the one you would repeat. Make the next yes match it. The first sale of this path is the second similar job, not a perfect history.

What if I am not sure I want to keep doing service?

Keep doing it long enough to write the notes. Three similar jobs. Then the file can carry more of the weight. Quitting before the notes exist leaves you with neither cash nor a product.

How is this different from the productized service path?

That path assumes you can name the package this week and sell it. This path is for people already in the messy middle of freelance. You convert what you have. The destination — a named package — is the same room.

Should I put the package on a fancy page?

A one-pager is enough until strangers you do not know are buying. Past clients will read a Google doc. Do not stall on Webflow.

How many revisions is one?

One round of grouped notes inside a dated window, usually 5 days. Not a drip of ‘quick tweaks’ for a month. Put that in the one-pager.

What goes in the product version vs the package?

The product version is the steps, prompts, examples, and definition of done — the job without you. The package is you running those steps on their mess, with judgment and a date.

The client wants hourly and I am scared to lose them.

Name the package once. If they still want hourly, cap the hours and the extras, or let them go. A client who only exists when the scope is fog is not a client you can productize around.

When do I raise the price?

When someone waits, or when you are full, or when the notes show the job is heavier than the old invoices implied. Add 15–30%. Do not add three new deliverables so you feel polite.

Can I productize more than one job?

Later. One package until the paste is automatic and the notes are boring. A second package is how you end up quoting from scratch again.

AI did 80% of the draft. Is charging \$750 honest?

If you edited, checked facts, matched voice, owned the result, and saved them a week in the blank window, yes. You are not selling keystrokes. You are selling a dated result they can use. If you are shipping unedited model text, fix the quality bar before you worry about the number.